

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a New York newspaper:

Students withdrawing from society

For nearly three years, Damo Miyawaki didn't talk to his family and friends. He seldom left his bedroom, sleeping during the day and staying up all night, surfing the web and reading Japanese comics. The only time he ever went outside was to eat, something he would do in the middle of the night to avoid any contact with other people.

Damo, now 18, was suffering from a serious health and social condition that is facing many young people in many countries. It causes young people to stay indoors, sometimes for years, watching TV, surfing the internet and reading, avoiding all social contact and often cutting off ties with family and friends. In Japan, around one million people, mostly men between the ages of 15 and 20, are said to suffer from the condition.

This problem is very painful and serious for families, who are unable to communicate with sufferers and face daily problems arising from the condition. Some children refuse to speak to their parents and just wait for food to be placed outside their bedroom door.

It can also affect the economy, with those suffering not working or earning money.

A specialist in this illness, Dr Kato states that, "Much work and social life is now carried out remotely, using technology, and this causes problems but there are also cultural reasons such as a sense of embarrassment and an emotional dependence on the mothers. Often sufferers just feel that there are too many social pressures on them and they decide to withdraw from society."

Your Liberal Studies class is discussing some of the social problems faced by young people today. You may want to talk about:

- why some young people avoid social contact
- why this is a problem for them and their families
- how to overcome these problems
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you prefer to stay at home or go out to meet friends?
2. How much time do you spend alone?
3. Why is it important to talk to family and friends?
4. Why is it difficult for some young people to talk to their families?
5. How can parents better communicate with their children?
6. Does the internet make the problem of withdrawing from society worse?
7. Will withdrawing from society become worse in the future?
8. What are the benefits of spending time alone?